Herald Tribune, permanently accredited to the Pentagon. He confirmed that report."[1]

The Soviet journalist to whom Dobrynin referred in his cable was in fact a KGB officer who had reported news that he picked up in a Washington bar to his superior, the head of the KGB Washington station, Aleksandr Feklisov. Feklisov in turn shared the information not only with his superiors in Moscow but also with the ambassador. Dobrynin, who had established a line of communication through Robert Kennedy to the president himself, was eager to maintain it as the only channel for confidential contacts with the two American leaders. He routinely downplayed the importance of his competitors, the KGB and military intelligence officers such as Feklisov and Georgii Bolshakov, in both Washington and Moscow. But this case was different. With the KGB reporting that Kennedy was going to invade Cuba within the next twenty-four hours, Dobrynin no longer sought to undermine his competitors but jumped on the intelligence services bandwagon, eager to deliver the information to Moscow as soon as possible.[2]

There was little doubt in Khrushchev's mind that he had to act quickly. Luckily, he had a solution ready in the form of the offer to Kennedy approved by the Presidium the previous day: he would remove the missiles from Cuba in exchange for a pledge not to invade the island. What remained was to call in the stenographer to take down Khrushchev's draft letter, which his aides would turn into a coherent text. By the afternoon of October 26, the letter was ready, and a courier delivered it to the US embassy in Moscow at 4:43 p.m. Moscow time. As always, it was a long and rambling missive, with a count of 2,748 words in English translation. It took hours to transmit the text to Washington, and the White House did not receive it until 9:15 p.m. that evening.[3]

Khrushchev began on a conciliatory note. "Dear Mr. President," read the text delivered to the embassy, "I have received your letter of October 25. From your letter, I got the feeling that you have some understanding of the situation which has developed and (some) sense of responsibility. I value this." He was referring to the terse letter in which Kennedy had declared his intention to go ahead with the blockade despite Soviet protests, but Khrushchev preferred not to mention that. He was pulling his punches